Box 1. The policy context for including environmental impacts in Australian HTA

Guidelines for Submission to the Medical Services Advisory Committee (TG 29.6)

The guidelines for submissions to Australia's Medical Services Advisory Committee (MSAC), who undertake HTA for public subsidy of medical services, state that "if there are particular concerns regarding the environmental impact of the proposed health technology, or a key benefit in the way the proposed technology reduces the environmental impact compared with the comparator, these can be outlined."[4]

National Health and Climate Strategy (Action 5.1)

The Australian Government's National Health and Climate Strategy states that "the Australian Government will, in consultation with industry and other relevant stakeholders, review options for including public reporting and consideration of environmental impacts, starting with greenhouse gas emissions, of health technologies, in collaboration and alignment with international best practice in comparable jurisdictions".[7]

Health Technology Assessment Policy and Methods Review (Recommendation 43)

The Health Technology Assessment Policy and Methods Review recommended "the Australian Government, in line with the National Health and Climate Strategy, investigate the following options in consultation with industry and other stakeholders:

a. Reporting of environmental impacts, starting with embodied greenhouse gas emissions, during the assessment of cost-effectiveness by Australian HTA bodies
b. Potential to use this data in approval and reimbursement decisions
c. Potential for public reporting of this data, to inform clinical decision-making
d. The development of guidance documents and examples to facilitate environmental impacts reporting
e. Alignment with international best practice in comparable jurisdictions
f. The role of international standards for calculating the carbon footprint of health technology products."[6]

Box 2. International efforts to include environmental impacts in HTA

England

The primary HTA body in England is the National Institute for Health and Care Excellence (NICE). HTAs conducted by the Technology Appraisal Committee of NICE determine which technologies are made available through the National Health Service (NHS). HTAs conducted by NICE do not currently consider environmental impacts. NICE's HTA Innovation Laboratory (HTA Lab), which exists to develop new HTA methods and processes, are undertaking a project to explore methods to compare the environmental impacts of health technologies. This project is focused on situations where health and cost outcomes are equivalent.[34] The project output includes a qualitative study of public opinions[33] and a review of available methods.[9]

Canada

The primary HTA body in Canada is Canada's Drug Agency (CDA), formerly known as the Canadian Agency for Drugs and Technologies in Health (CADTH). HTAs are conducted by the Health Technology Expert Review Panel (HTERP) in the CDA for all non-drug health technologies.[35] Recommendations are made by HTERP using a multi-criteria framework which explicitly includes environmental impacts as one of eleven framework domains.[36] However, current evidence suggests that environmental impacts are rarely incorporated into HTA.[27,37] The CDA has also committed to adapting their methods and analyses to include environmental perspectives, and to assess how technologies impact the environmental footprint of health systems.[38] The Institut national d'excellence en santé et en services sociaux in Quebec has also performed HTA that consider environmental impacts.[37]